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Writing women's worlds

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As time went on, however, their sense of just what kind of "halfie" I was became more precise. They began to focus on the fact that I was part Palestinian. The women with whom I spent most of my time were more concerned with my marital and family situation than my Palestinian identity. They were glad when I married so they could share with me more easily the jokes about what goes on between husbands and wives. Yet they also pitied me for the unaccountable delay in having children. They, like the Bedouin men I knew well, could not understand what satisfaction writing books and articles or teaching might have. They knew it was good to get degrees and a job, but was the point not simply to make a good salary? The real part of life was family, and I seemed to them to be living in a strangely lonesome world, just myself and my husband. They prayed for me and implored God to grant me children.

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The men, though, talked more and more about Palestine. Once or twice when I came back after being away, they would proudly tell me they had heard my father interviewed on the radio. One time they brought a poet to recite before me a poem he had  40 composed about the Israeli invasion of Lebanon and the tragedy of Palestine. I was intrigued when, in a conversation between two tribal leaders about the loss of their coastal land through confiscation and sales and the influx of urban Egyptians and peasants to traditional Awlad 'Ali territory, the men agreed that they were being "Palestinianized." Most recently, with the publicity about the Palestinian *intifada*, people impressed with the courage of the young boys throwing rocks at soldiers began to ask me more about the Palestinians. Why did they not use guns? Why does the United States help Israel? As this latter question showed, my North American identity was not ignored either. After the U.S. bombing in 1986 of Libya, the country

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from which Awlad 'Ali say they originate and to which they still have strong ties, they challenged me about the American position. I can only imagine what they will ask when I next return, after the war in the Gulf.

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